

Macromedia Flash

Compacting .fla Files?

 Suppose you have to post an 11.8 MB Flash document (the .FLA) to a Web server. Although you have a high-speed connection, there still has to be a better way. And there is:

Open any Flash file in Flash MX 2004, and choose File > Save and Compact. This feature can compact the 11.8 MB monster FLA file to about 2.3 MB. Especially useful for those with slower connections.

Find And Replace

 If you've ever been in the situation where you have to find every instance of something in Flash and replace it with another, you know what a nightmare it can be. If you have not experienced this yet, trust us, you don't want to. There is a simple way to find and replace. Go to Edit > Find and Replace, to open the Find and Replace dialog box. From here, you can locate and replace text, fonts, symbols, sounds, video clips, bitmaps, and even colour. Yes, even colour can be replaced.

Here's an example: Draw a circle and a box on the 'Stage', and convert them to symbols called 'circle' and 'box'. Leave them both there. Go to Edit>Find and Replace.

In the dialog box, choose 'Current Scene' from the 'Search In' menu.

Choose 'Symbol' from the 'For' menu.

Choose 'Box' from the 'Name' menu. This command will locate all instances of the box symbol.

Choose 'circle' from the 'Replace With' menu.

Click Replace All.

Erase Your Mistakes

 You have filled up your stage with what you thought was creative. Unfortunately, the layout is all wrong, the custom scrollbar is the worst ever, and the text seems to have been written by a three-year-old. It's clean up time!

Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

GENERAL TIPS

Macromedia Flash	79
Dreamweaver MX	80
Microsoft Word	83
Microsoft Excel	85

30 MINUTES EXPERT

GMail Storage	81
The Windows swap file	84

To erase everything on the Stage, double-click the 'Eraser' tool in the toolbar. Problem solved! Note, however, that this works only one frame at a time.

When the playhead is at frame 10, you can erase everything on the Stage at frame 10, but nothing else.

To erase other frames, you have to move the playhead to those frames manually before you can go ahead with erasing.

Lower File Sizes

 When you are using a lot of bitmap images in a Flash movie, file size can add up fast. You can use the 'Publish' settings to set the JPEG quality for the entire movie, but that can lead to inconsistency. One image may look great, while another, grainy and smudgy.

To customise the 'Publish' settings for individual bitmap images, right-click on the image's name in the Library and

choose 'Properties'. In the 'Bitmap Properties' dialog box, deselect 'Use document default quality' and change the number in the 'Quality' field. A higher number yields higher-quality images with a larger file size, and vice-versa.

Once you have set the number, click 'Test'. The dialog box reports the starting file size and the new file size for the image. Typically, setting the quality to 50 can make a 700 KB image publish at less than 20 KB.

You can also use the mouse to drag the image around in the preview pane of the dialog box to see how it would look. If it's grainy, increase the number in the 'Quality' field.

Flash Text And Search Engines

 When you create text in Flash MX 2004, you need to remember that unlike HTML, Flash MX 2004 text will not be picked up by search engine bots. So, you need to add Meta Tags to the HTML document that the SWF file will reside in.

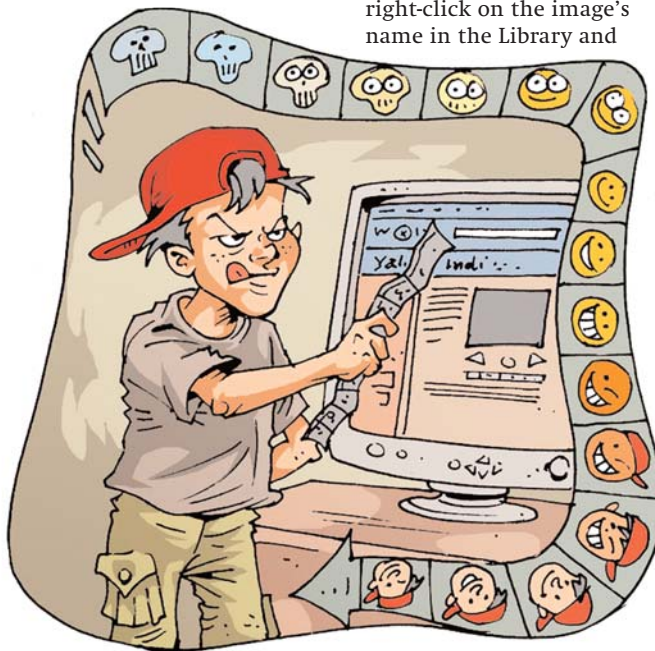
Static Text And Device Fonts

 Static text is display text that doesn't change onscreen, such as the information displayed in an interface, or for button labels, forms, and navigation.

When you add static text to your movie, by default, Flash MX 2004 will embed the font outlines in the SWF file for the font you are using. Depending on the font you choose, and how much text you use, this can add considerably to the overall file size.

If you want smaller file sizes, use a device font. A device font is a font that won't be embedded in the SWF file. Instead, you choose a device font for the end users' machines to display—_serif, _sans, or _typewriter—and the end users' machines will display that device font for the Static text.

This will help keep your file size small.



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